

Age and Hair Style Choice and its Influence on Peoples' Emotions

Yosolaoluwa Olakunle

University of California, Berkeley

Abstract

This study investigated how age and hair styling choices influence individuals' emotions. Previous research has explored hair-related attitudes across broad age groups and styling preferences, we explore two independent variables: age and style choice. I hypothesized that younger individuals would exhibit more positive emotions, as natural hair and protective styles are more widely accepted today. Additionally, I predict that those with styled hair would experience more favorable emotions compared to those with unstyled hair. Participants (N=40, ages 13+) completed self-report measures assessing their hair-related emotions, age, and styling choices. Results revealed no significant relationship between age and hair related emotions ($\beta=-0.47$, $p=0.148$), between styling choices and emotions ($\beta=0.11$, $p=0.609$), and lastly between age, styling choices and emotions ($p=.302$). Deeper research and findings may inform interventions and initiatives focused on promoting positive self-perception and fostering inclusive societal norms.

Introduction

In a world where personal appearance holds significant social currency, understanding how people perceive and feel about their hair is a fascinating avenue of exploration. From age to styling choices, each factor may shape one's emotional connection to their hair, offering insights into self image and societal norms.

An individual's emotional state and actions depending on the state of their hair is an important variable because it delves into the intricate relationship between self-image, societal

expectations, and personal grooming habits. Understanding people's feelings depending on the state of their hair can provide valuable insights into their psychological well-being and self-esteem (Hervey, 2016). Previous studies have approached this variable through qualitative interview, self-report questionnaires, and observational studies (D'Ardenne, 2022). These methods have helped psychologists uncover the emotional significance people attach to their hair and how it influences their behavior and self-perception.

Age, as defined by psychologists, is the chronological measure of an individual's lifespan (American Psychological Association, 2023). Past research has shown that age significantly influences people's attitude toward their hair, with younger individuals often placing more emphasis on experimentation and trendiness, while older individuals may prioritize hair health and maintenance (UPGUYS Editorial Team, 2023). However, past research has primarily focused on broad age categories and has not delved deeply into the nuances of age-related differences within specific demographic groups. Addressing this limitation will allow for a more comprehensive understanding of how age influences people's attitudes based on their hair.

Another independent variable that might be related to hair-related emotions is styling choice, specifically whether an individual's hair is styled or unstyled. Styling choices encompass various factors such as hairstyle, hair products used, and grooming habits. Past research has shown that styling preferences can reflect cultural norms, personal identity, and social influences (Mages, 2023). Understanding the impact of styling choices on hair-related emotions is crucial, it can shed light on the role of self-expression and conformity in shaping individuals' attitudes toward their appearance.

The goal of this research is to investigate how age and styling choices influence individuals' feelings toward their hair. By examining these two independent variables, the goal is to uncover the nuanced interplay between age and stylistic choices in shaping hair-related emotions. The study will branch out from past research by exploring within a specific demographic and by examining the role of styling preferences in moderating the relationship between age and hair-related emotions.

Hypotheses

Based on existing literature and my research goals, I propose the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1

Null: There is no significant relationship between how people feel based on their hair and age.

Alternative: There is a significant relationship between how people feel based on their hair and their age.

Hypothesis 2

Null: There is no significant relationship between how people feel based on their hair and whether it is styled or not.

Alternative: There is a significant relationship between how people feel based on their hair and whether their hair is styled or not.

Hypothesis 3

Null: There is no significant relationship between how people feel based on their hair and their age as well as whether their hair is styled.

Alternative: There are significant relationships between how people feel based on their hair and their age, as well as whether their hair is styled or not.

Method

Participants

The study included a sample of 40 participants (originally 42 but two participants were discarded due to survey error), consisting of 35 individuals aged 13-27 and 5 individuals aged 28 and above. Participants were recruited through social media channels and in person advertisement, with no specific incentives provided for participation.

Procedures

Participants were asked to complete an online survey (Google Form) that assess their emotional state and feelings toward their hair. The survey included questions related to their racial identity, age, styling choices, and continuous measure of hair-related emotions. Participants were instructed to respond to the questions based on their current state and experiences.

Measures**Dependent Variables: Hair-related emotions**

A continuous measure of hair-related emotions was developed specifically for this study. Participants were asked to rate their level of agreement with various statements related to their feelings toward their hair on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from "Strongly Disagree" to "Strongly Agree". Examples of statements included "On a scale of 1(Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree), how much do you disagree/agree that your hair in its current state has made you feel depressed," "[...]your hair in its current state has made you go out and have more fun," and "[...] your hair in its current state has made you avoid going out."

Independent Variable 1 (IV1): Age

Participants self-reported their age in years. For the purposes of analysis, age was treated as a continuous variable.

Independent Variable 2 (IV2): Styling Choices

Participants were asked to indicate whether they currently style their hair or leave it unstyled.

This variable was treated as a categorical variable.

Results

Descriptive Statistics

The age distribution was bimodal (Figure 1), with 35 participants in the 13-27 age group and 5 participants in the 28+ age groups. Additionally, 22 participants reported having styled hair (Figure 2), while 18 reported unstyled hair. The distributions of participants' feelings based on their hair was uniform, with a Mean = 2.84 and SD= 0.67, so feelings toward hair were relatively in the middle.

Figures

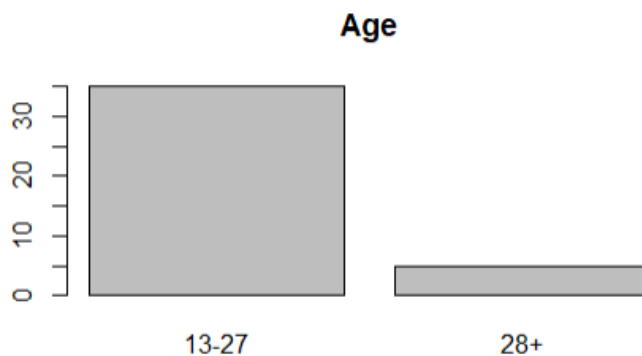
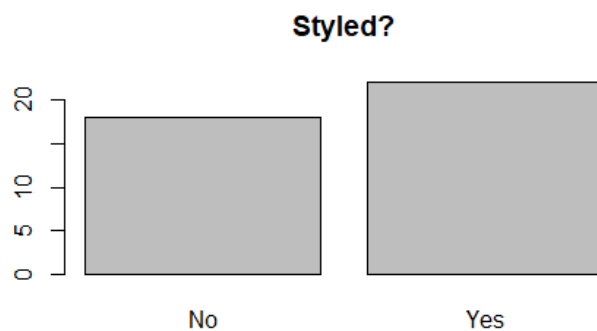


Figure 1



*Figure 2***Linear Models and Inferential Statistics**

Table 1 presents the results of three linear models predicting hair-related emotions from age and styling choices.

DV = Hair-related emotions	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Intercept	2.90	2.78	2.83
IV1	-0.47 (0.31), CI [-1.11, 0.17]		-0.48 (0.32), CI: [-1.13, 0.17]
IV2		0.11 (0.22), CI [-0.33, 0.55]	0.12 (0.21), CI: [-0.31, 0.56]
R ²	Multiple: 0.05, adjusted: 0.03	Multiple: 0., adjusted:	Mult: 0.06, adj: 0.01

Table1. Predicting Hair-Related Emotions from Age and Styling Choices

Note: Standard errors are reported in parenthesis. CI=95% Confidence Interval

Hypothesis 1 (Model 1/ Figure 3)

To test this hypothesis, we defined a linear regression model with hair-related emotions as the dependent variable and age as the independent variable (Model 1). The slope for age was -0.47 (SE=0.31), with a 95% confidence interval of [-1.11, 0.17], $t(38)=-1.477$, $p=0.148$. As age increased, hair related-emotions tended to decrease, but this effect was not statistically significant. The wide confidence intervals and low t-value further indicate a lack of significance. Overall, the data demonstrated did not support the alternative hypothesis, failing to reject the null hypothesis.

Hypothesis 2 (Model 2/Figure 4)

To test the hypothesis hypothesis, we defined a linear regression model with hair-related variables emotions as dependent variable and styling choice as the independent variable (Model 2). The slope for styling choices was 0.11 (SE=0.22), with a 95% confidence interval of [-0.33, 0.55], $t(38)=0.516$, $p=0.609$. Individuals with styled hair tended to have slightly more positive hair-related emotions compared to those with unstyled hair, but this effect was not statistically significant. The wide confidence intervals interval, low t-value, and large p-value indicate a lack of significance. Overall, the data did not support not support the alternative hypothesis, failing to reject the null hypothesis.

Hypothesis 3 (Model 3)

To test the hypothesis, we defined a multivariate linear hypothesis model with hair related emotions as the dependent variable and both age and styling choices as independent variableindependent variables (Model 3). Controlling for styling choices, the effect of age on hair-related emotions became marginally significant ($\beta=-0.48$, SE= 0.32, $p= 0.15$). This suggests that when accounting for the potential influence of styling choices, age may play a more substantial role in shaping hair-related emotions. The overall model explained a small portion of the variance in hair-related emotions ($R^2= 0.06$, adjusted $R^2= 0.01$).

While the multivariate model revealed a marginally significant effect of the independent variables on hair-related emotions, the data did not provide strong evidence to reject the null hypothesis in favor of the alternative hypothesis.

Figures

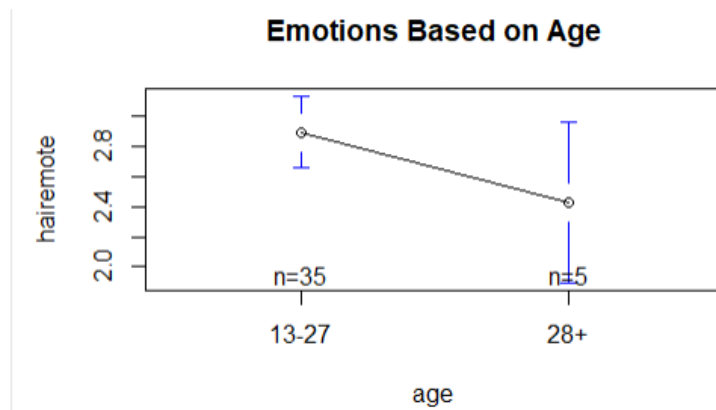


Figure 3

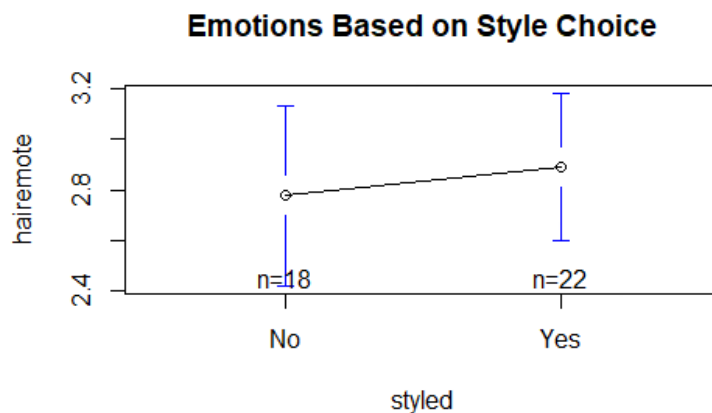


Figure 4

Discussion

This study aimed to investigate the influence of age and styling choices on individuals' emotional connection to their hair. Contrary to my hypotheses, the results did not reveal significant main effects of age or styling choices on hair-related emotions.

These findings suggest that while age and styling choices independently may not significantly impact hair-related emotions, their combined influence warrants further investigation. It is possible that the relationship between age and hair-related emotions is more nuanced and may be moderated or mediated by other factors, such as cultural norms, self-esteem, or body image.

One limitation of the current study is the relatively small sample size, particularly for the older age group. A larger and more diverse sample could provide greater statistical power and allow for more robust analyses of age related differences. Additionally, the study relied on self-report measures, which may be subject to biases and social desirability effects.

Future research could explore the role of additional variables, such as gender, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status, in shaping hair-related emotions. Qualitative methods, such as interviews or focus groups could also provide deeper insights into the lived experiences and personal narratives surrounding hair and self-perception.

Furthermore, longitudinal studies could track changes in hair-related emotions over time, shedding light on how these emotions evolve across different life stages and in response to significant life events or transitions.

In conclusion, while the current study did not find strong evidence for the hypothesized relationships, it highlights the complex interplay between age, styling choices, and hair-related emotions. By continuing to explore this topic, researchers can contribute to a better understanding of self-image, societal influences, and the psychological significance of personal grooming and appearance.

References

1. Ellis-Hervey, N., Doss, A., Davis, D., Nicks, R., & Araiza, P. (2016). African American Personal Presentation: Psychology of Hair and Self-Perception. *JSTOR*.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/26174232>
2. Arizona State University. (2022, May 24). Study shows Black girls commonly have negative experiences related to their natural hair. *ASU News*.

<https://news.asu.edu/20220524-study-shows-black-girls-commonly-have-negative-experiences-related-their-natural-hair>

3. The Autoethnographer. (n.d.). Home. Retrieved [date you accessed the site], from <https://theautoethnographer.com/>
4. American Psychological Association. (n.d.). Age. In *APA Dictionary of Psychology*. Retrieved [date you accessed the entry], from <https://dictionary.apa.org/age>
5. UPGUYS. (n.d.). Hair growth rate by age. Retrieved [date you accessed the article], from <https://upguys.com/blog/hair-growth-rate-by-age>